

Conflict in Relationships

Conflict Outcomes

1. Destructive Conflict - damages the relationship or leaves both parties worse off than before.

- This occurs when the goal becomes winning, hurting, or defending face, rather than understanding.

Conflict Outcomes – Destructive conflict

Key Features	Description
Escalation	Communication intensifies; hostility increases.
Polarization	Parties become entrenched — “my side vs. yours.”
Rigidity	No openness to alternative viewpoints.
Verbal Aggression	Attacks on identity rather than ideas.
Withdrawal / Stonewalling	Disengagement or emotional shutdown.

Conflict Outcomes

2. Constructive Conflict

Focuses on problem-solving, perspective-taking, and relational repair.

- Increases understanding, trust, and intimacy.

Conflict Outcomes – Constructive conflict

Key Features	Description
Perspective-taking	Each side recognizes the other's goals and emotions.
Cooperative framing	Shared problem orientation ("we have an issue," not "you are the issue").
Open communication	Direct but respectful expression of feelings and needs.
Flexibility	Willingness to compromise or explore multiple solutions.

Conflict Outcomes

3. Conflict Transformation

Goes beyond “resolving” an issue to transforming the relationship itself.

- Conflict isn’t something to *end* — it’s an opportunity to *transform* the relationship and underlying structures that produced it.

Involves shifts in perception, identity, or power structure.

Conflict Outcomes – Conflict transformation

Feature	Constructive conflict	Conflict Transformation
Goal	End the dispute	Change the relationship and system
Focus	Solving specific problem	Understanding deeper causes and needs
Timeframe	Short-term	Long-term, ongoing process
Outcome	Agreement or settlement	Growth, empowerment, redefined connection
Example	“Let’s agree on chores.”	“Let’s rethink how we share responsibility and communicate expectations.”

Conflict styles

Why do couples use hostile conflict styles more often than other, more positive conflict styles?

- Hostile styles = competitive fighting and indirect fighting
- One explanation is the principle of negative reciprocity

The principle of negative reciprocity

Aggression creates more aggression

- Aggressive and hostile behaviors are returned.

There are at least three problems related to negative reciprocity.

Negative reciprocity



The principle of negative reciprocity

- 1 and 2. Gunnysacking and kitchen-sinking
 - Gunnysacking = storing up past grievances and dumping them (all at once) on a partner during a conflict.
 - Kitchen-sinking = rehashing old arguments during a conflict.
- Because multiple attacks are involved, partners feel defensive and overwhelmed
 - And probably unable to discuss an issue productively.

Gunnysacking example



The principle of negative reciprocity

- 3. Bringing other people into the conflict
 - Promotes feelings defensiveness, which make problem resolution very difficult.
 - Mentioning negative things other people have said about the partner.
 - Saying negative things about the partner's friends or family.
 - Comparing partner to former partners

The principle of negative reciprocity

NR is a common pattern and can predict relationship dissatisfaction.

- For satisfying relationships, positive interactions should greatly outnumber negative interactions
 - Ratio of 5: 1
 - Five positive to one negative

Conflict styles

Why do couples use hostile conflict styles more often than other, more positive conflict styles?

- Hostile styles = competitive fighting and indirect fighting
- Another explanation is the demand-withdraw pattern.

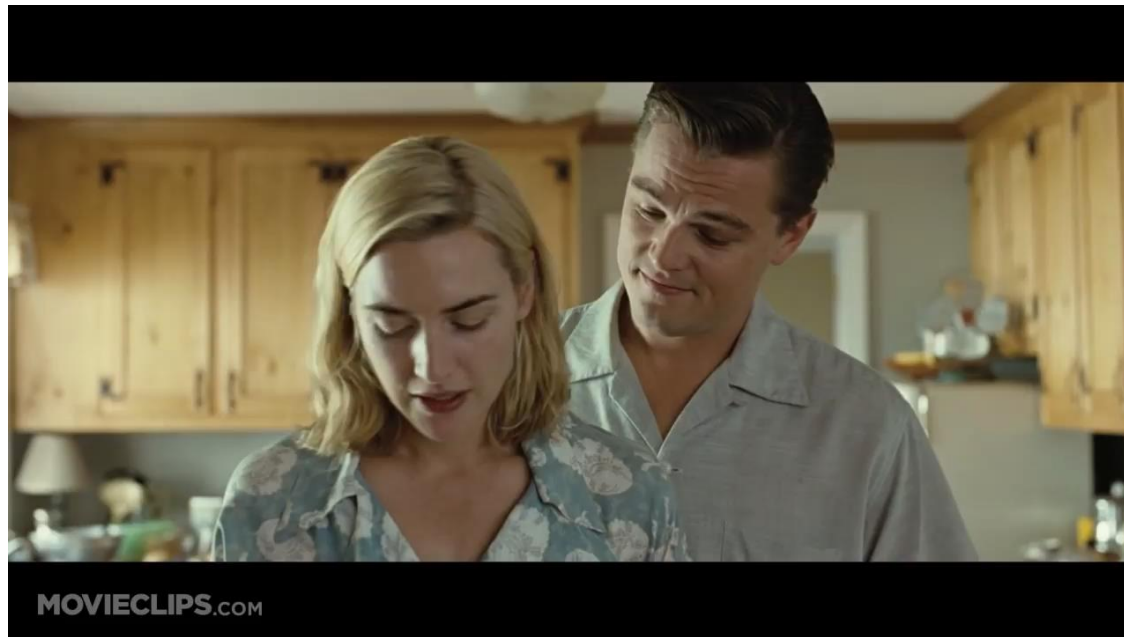
Demand-withdraw

One person wants to engage in discussion of an issue (the demander)

and the other wants to avoid or end discussion (the withdrawer).

- Works “both ways”
- More demands create more withdrawing
- More withdrawing creates more demands

Demand-withdraw



Demand-withdraw

- Demander uses highly charged emotional requests, criticism, complaints.
- Withdrawer uses defensiveness and passive inaction.

Demand-withdraw

Why does the D-W pattern happen?

- Often a result of “saving up” complaints over a period of time.
- Can be a symptom of an inequitable relationships (the demander is trying to obtain more power).
- Intergenerational effects
- Unresolved tension between connection – autonomy

4 manifestations of the Demand-Withdraw pattern

1. Discuss/exit

- One partner seeks discussion of an issue; the other partner exits physically or communicatively.

4 manifestations of the Demand-Withdraw pattern

2. Perfunctory response

- One partner asks a series of questions; the other gives inauthentic responses.
- Partner A: Will you take care of the cat's box?
 - Partner B: Yes.
- Partner A: When will you do it?
 - Partner B: Later.
- Partner A: What does that mean?
 - Partner B: I don't know, later.
- Partner A: I need you to tell me.
 - Partner B: Ok.

4 manifestations of the Demand-Withdraw pattern

3. Complain/deny

- One partner complains about an issue; the other partner denies the legitimacy of the issue.
- Partner A: Did you take care of the cat's box like you said you would?
- Partner B: I don't know why you keep bringing this up. It's not a big deal.

4 manifestations of the Demand-Withdraw pattern

4. Criticize/Defend

- Partner A: You are being disrespectful about the cat's box.
- Partner B: I'm not being disrespectful -- you are, by bringing it up all the time.

Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse

Model for understanding how conflict can negatively impact relationships.

Developed, tested, and extensively researched by Dr. John Gottman and his wife, Dr. Julie Gottman

Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse

- Criticism
 - Defensiveness
 - Contempt
 - Stonewalling
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- Couples who end up divorcing exhibit conflict patterns that include these four components.

Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse

- 1. Criticism
 - Criticism = Complaint + negative words about partner's character or personality.
 - “Why are you so selfish? I always have to take care of the cat's litter box. You really just don't care.”
 - This is the beginning of serious `relationship problems and sets the stage for the other “horsemen” to enter the relationship.

Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse

- Complaint = addresses a specific action at which your partner failed.
- More productive than criticism.
- “I’m upset that you didn’t take care of the cat’s litter box last night. We agreed it was your turn.”

Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse

2. Contempt/disgust

- With partner as a “whole person”
- Fueled by long-standing problems in a relationship.
- Suggests superiority (“I’m better than you.”)

Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse

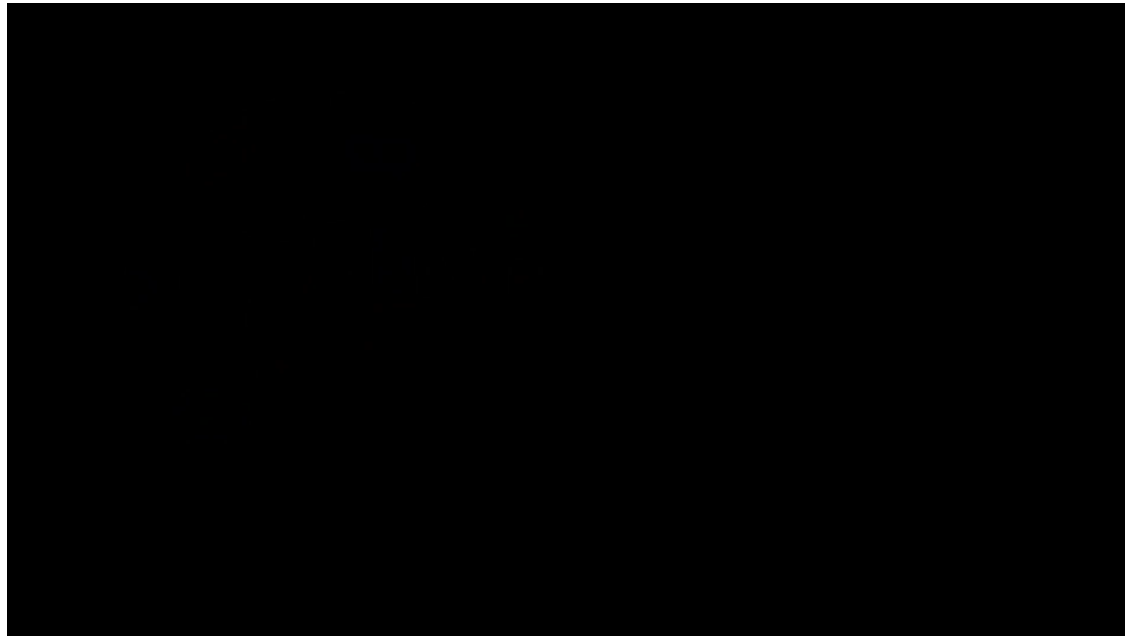
- Contempt/disgust might involve:
 - Hostile humor
 - Name calling
 - Mockery
 - Insult
 - Sarcasm
 - Eye rolling
 - “You’re crazy.”
 - “You can’t do anything right.”

Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse

Contempt/disgust

- Contempt/disgust with partner is **very stressful**
- couples that are contemptuous of each other are more likely to suffer from infectious illness (colds, the flu, etc.) than others
 - their immune systems weaken

Effect of stress



Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse

Short term stress vs. chronic stress

- Chronic stress prompts the release of cortisol, epinephrine, norepinephrine from the adrenal gland and can lead to:
 - Hypertension
 - Cholesterol plaque build up
 - IBS
 - Weight gain
 - Weakened immune system

Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse

Coping with stress:

- 1. Change relationship
- 2. Terminate relationship
- 3. Exercise
- 4. Meditation

Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse

3. Defensiveness

- Occurs when people feel the need to protect themselves from personal attacks.
 - Problem does not get resolved – “It’s not me, it’s you.”
- Defensive behaviors include:
 - denying responsibility
 - issuing counter-complaints
 - making excuses
 - making accusations to deflect responsibility

Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse

4. Stonewalling

- Occurs after chronic criticism, contempt, and defensiveness.
- Partners “turn to stone” – they disengage, stop communicating, and see **continued interactions as futile**.

Canary and Cupach's Conflict Frames

- A conflict frame is the mental lens or interpretive filter through which a person perceives, defines, and approaches a conflict situation.
- Two people can be arguing about the same issue, yet interpret it very differently because they frame it differently.

Canary and Cupach's Conflict Frames

1. Outcome Frame

Core idea: Conflict is about achieving a desired end state — winning, gaining resources, or securing agreement.

- “How can I get what I want?”

Example: “I just want you to admit that I’m right about this.”

Canary and Cupach's Conflict Frames

2. Process Frame

Core idea: Conflict is about the fairness or quality of the communication process.

- “Are we handling this the right way?”

Example: “You shut down every time I try to talk about problems.”

Canary and Cupach's Conflict Frames

3. Identity (or Relational) Frame

Core idea: Conflict is about face, self-concept, and relationship roles.

- “What does this say about me or us?”

Example: “You make me feel like I’m not good enough.”

Canary and Cupach's Conflict Frames

4. Emotion Frame

Core idea: Conflict revolves around feelings and emotional experiences.

- “How do I feel, and how do you make me feel?”

Example: “I feel unloved when you don’t text back.”

Canary and Cupach's Conflict Frames

Frame mismatch: When two people are “in different conflicts” because they frame it differently.

This makes resolution difficult (or impossible).

Canary and Cupach's Conflict Frames

Person A	Person B	Frame mismatch	Result
"We need to decide who's right about this."	"You never listen when I try to explain."	Outcome vs. Process	Disagreement escalates over "how" rather than "what."
"You're treating me like I'm incompetent."	"I just want this done correctly."	Identity vs. Outcome	One defends dignity; the other defends results.
"You don't care about how I feel."	"Let's just solve the problem."	Emotion vs. Outcome	Emotional needs ignored, practical goals prioritized.

Canary and Cupach's Conflict Frames

Conflict reframing - deliberately changing the interpretive lens to make resolution more possible.

"matching" conflict frames.

Canary and Cupach's Conflict Frames

If You Hear...	Underlying Frame	Try Reframing to...
"You never let me talk."	Process	"Let's take turns and really listen."
"You don't respect me."	Identity	"I value you — let's find a way to talk respectfully."
"You always overreact."	Emotion	"I want to understand why this feels so intense."
"I'm not backing down."	Outcome	"What would a fair solution look like for both of us?"